The crowd trouble before and during the game was a real blow, like going back to the bad old days: the idiots, too many of them to ignore, letting the rest of the England fans—and the England team—down. Afterwards, I found myself thinking that having to play our next game behind closed doors might not be such a bad thing. That was the threat from UEFA when they had their inquiry into the racist chanting and the field invasions at the Stadium of Light. I felt so strongly that I said it in public. If it took England having to play in an empty stadium to make people realize the damage done to our game by the racists and the troublemakers, then so be it.

The crowd trouble took some of the shine off the night at the Stadium of Light. There were as many headlines about the hooligans as there were about the team. That was a shame because it was another England performance of which we could all be proud. We beat one of Europe's strongest teams 2–0 and went top of our group. The previous Saturday, we'd been away to Liechtenstein and won by the same score. The pundits, as well as some of our supporters, had given us a roasting: how could England expect to be at the finals if they struggled to beat a bunch of part-timers? But soccer's about results. We'd had a bad result, even though we'd played some decent soccer against Macedonia. Other than that, despite playing in some difficult conditions, we'd won all our games in Group 7. Sven always says it: get three points. You win the games you're expected to win and it doesn't matter too much how you do it. When the big games come round, that's when you expect to find your big performance to match.

Turkey retain possession as well as any team in the world. It's what they base their game around and, if you let them, they'll take a defense to pieces. Sven said how important it was for us to break up their rhythm and to impose our own game on them. As captain, I thought it was up to me to try and lead by example. In the first half I did fly into a tackle or two and it cost me a yellow card but that's not something I regret. I know it sounds a bit old-fashioned but getting physical against Turkey was what we needed to do. They had their fair share of the ball but never got time to settle into any kind of pattern. I felt, all night, we were the team that would score. Turkey hadn't ever seen many like Wayne Rooney: none of us have. Even though he didn't score, the lad lifted us—and scared them to death—every time he got the ball. Michael Owen was making great runs off him and I was sure he'd get the goal. As it turned out, though, Michael picked up an injury after an hour and Darius Vassell came on and hit in a rebound from Rio Ferdinand's header. David James made one fantastic save and then Kieron Dyer won a penalty. Well into injury time and the game already won: it wasn't exactly Argentina at the World Cup. I felt fantastic whacking it in all the same.